

Epistemology



It soon became apparent to philosophers in ancient Greece that there was an underlying problem with all the questions they were attempting to answer, best summed up by the simple question: ‘How can we know that?’ This, and similar questions about what sort of thing we can know (if anything), how we can acquire knowledge and the nature of knowledge itself, have preoccupied Western philosophy ever since, forming the branch of philosophy known as epistemology.

Some philosophers believe that we acquire knowledge by experience and through the evidence provided to us by our senses – a view known as empiricism; others think that knowledge is primarily acquired by a process of reasoning, a view known as rationalism. The division between empiricism and rationalism helped to define various schools of philosophy until the 19th century. Other areas of epistemology, meanwhile, deal with the connection between knowledge and concepts such as truth and belief.